

Who Could Possibly be Interested in Visiting Us? Circular Business Model Innovation in a Collaborative Rural Hub

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Abstract

The shift towards remote and hybrid work enables people to pursue individual lifestyles, further away from their place of work. However, remote areas typically face challenges related to service provision and social activities. Using a qualitative case study approach, the paper investigates how circular business model innovation (CBMI) unfolds in a collaborative ecosystem of small enterprises located in rural Sweden: ‘Climbers’ Hub’, comprising coworking, hotel, and climbing related services. Data were collected through interviews, observations, and document review, and analysed using existing knowledge of CBMI. The study finds that CBMI benefits from holistic circular, community- and place-based strategies and objectives, resulting in ecosocial benefits. Through the CBMI lens, the study offers novel insights into how small enterprises operate in a rural context. The knowledge generated is valuable to researchers and educators seeking to understand CBMI, and to practitioners who aim to implement circular business models (CBM) in small enterprises.

Keywords Adaptive Reuse · Circular Business Model Innovation · Community · Coworking · Rural Areas · Small and Medium-sized Enterprises

1. Introduction

The rise of remote and digital nomadism work has granted many people greater freedom to pursue individual lifestyles (Orel, 2019). This shift has resulted in migration patterns away from cities (Ramani et al., 2024; Ramani & Bloom, 2021), and the motivation for urban-rural migration often includes a desire for a sustainable life and better work-leisure balance (Benson & O’Reilly, 2009; Orel, 2019). The decision to relocate to rural areas is often based on multiple factors, such as, the loss of workplace ties (Stockdale, 2014), social networks (Farrell et al., 2012), lifestyles (Benson & O’Reilly, 2016), and access to affordable housing (Steinführer et al., 2024; Stockdale, 2014).

However, rural areas often face limited services and activities. This decline is driven not only by population loss but also by increased mobility and online access, which reduce demand for local services (Bosworth and Salemin, 2021; Schiffing et al., 2015; Tomaney and Bradley, 2007). Additionally, pressure to reduce costs in the public sector has led to cutting of service provision (Cowie et al., 2020). The loss of services also diminishes space for social interactions (Schiffing et al., 2015).

Coworking spaces (CWS) can address these challenges by supporting remote workers and contributing to rural regeneration (Rex & Westlund, 2024). Further, they provide social interaction and reduce isolation (Orel, 2019). As a business model (BM), CWS represent access-based consumption which aligns with sharing and circular economy principles (Berbégall-Mirabent, 2021; Lundgren et al., 2022).

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Business model innovation oriented towards circularity (hereinafter CBMI) has the potential of implementing solutions that address environmental, social and economic (Bocken et al., 2019; Pieroni et al., 2019) as well as local sustainability (Meidell Dybdahl, 2019). Business models (BM) describe the way that businesses create, deliver and capture value and comprise the core elements of a business, including, both services or products provided, and supporting functions (e.g., Osterwalder & Pigneur, 2013; Teece, 2010; Zott & Amit, 2010). Innovation, on the other hand, typically refers to novel and implemented solutions to reach an overall objective (OECD & Eurostat, 2018). The concept of business model innovation (BMI), then, relates to innovations carried out in multiple functions of a BM (see e.g., OECD & Eurostat, 2018).

Guidance on the implementation of CBMI is not only limited (e.g., Bocken et al., 2019), but also heterogeneous, and skewed by different understandings of circularity (Kirchherr et al., 2017). Most existing studies focus on the urban context (Bähr et al., 2020; Thornton et al., 2023) missing the challenges of the rural context (Bosworth and Salemin, 2021; Schiffing et al., 2015; Tomaney and Bradley, 2007). This urban-centrism overlooks the fact that the operating context is significantly more critical for smaller firms than for larger corporations, as shown by Ferasso et al. (2023). Applying urban-derived circular models to rural SMEs without accounting for their unique environmental and social preconditions creates a significant theoretical and practical disconnect.

While SME circularity is often studied at firm level, there is a need to explore the SMEs' external ecosystem and the influence of inter-organizational collaborations in rural areas. A research stream for rural tourism entrepreneurship was identified by Kipinski et al. (2026), and Thirumalesh Madanaguli et al. (2021) suggest examining challenges and obstacles of rural hospitality and tourism, analysing what influences innovation and value creation, also including personal motivation and characteristics shaping entrepreneurial processes, and how networks contribute to rural SMEs. Rural development has recently been connected to circular economy by Labrousche et al. (2025). Here, the importance of networks but also the relevance of heritage and frugality in the rural context are noted, and a conclusion of the study is that rural innovations may imply open innovation (Labrousche et al., 2025).

This study directly addresses the research gap by providing an in-depth analysis of how a rural operating context shapes CBMI and its implementation. Further, by investigating an extreme case, we respond to the call for research that explores how SMEs leverage their specific local environments to overcome the resource constraints typical of small-scale operations. The aim is to establish how CBMI unfolds within a small enterprise ecosystem operating in a rural context, and it is operationalized through the following RQs, namely:

- RQ1: What is the role of objectives and personal motivation?
- RQ2: How does community and circular orientation contribute to BMI?
- RQ3: How does the implementation process unfold and what are the main challenges?

Using a qualitative single case study approach, the paper investigates a unique site in rural Sweden that combines a CWS with other services and activities. Data were collected through a site visit, interviews, and document review, and analysed using thematic analysis informed by CBMI related literature.

The paper is structured, as follows. The next section will introduce existing literature on BMI for circularity and sustainability, and on rural CWS as circular businesses. Following, the applied method is explained. Next, the findings comprise insights on the aspects of innovation for this case of CBMI. The implications of these findings are discussed and concluded in the last two sections of this paper.

2. Existing knowledge

The following sub-section offers a critical examination of the key contextual literature on BMs generally, circularity and sustainability related BMs specifically, as well as innovation related to both. The second sub-section is focused on introducing rural CWS as a circular business.

2.1. Business model innovation for circularity and sustainability

Definitions of BMs differ in emphasis and theoretical grounding. Teece (2010) views the BM primarily as a mechanism for creating and capturing value, linking it closely to strategy and competitive advantage. Osterwalder & Pigneur (2013) define the BM as the logic of how an organization creates, delivers, and captures

value, and emphasize for who and why a business does this. Zott & Amit (2010) conceptualize BMs as systems of interdependent activities that structure transactions across firm boundaries, highlighting networks and governance. With their concept of activity systems, they highlight the engagement of human, physical and capital resources to fulfil an overall objective (Zott & Amit, 2010).

Sustainable BMs (SBM) can be defined as those that incorporate and create value for multiple stakeholders, while also holding a long-term perspective (Geissdoerfer et al., 2018). CBMs, in turn, are effective contributors to sustainable development through resource efficiency. The circular economy offers guiding principles for decoupling resource consumption and environmental impact from economic growth (Santa-Maria et al., 2021; Stahel, 2019). CBMs can be characterized according to the R-imperatives, i.e., value retention strategies (Reike et al., 2018). The most effective strategies are refuse, reduce, and reuse, followed by repair and refurbish (Reike et al., 2018; Santa-Maria et al., 2021). In the real estate context, these most efficient strategies have been to reduce the demand for new construction through shared spaces (Lundgren et al., 2022), and adaptive reuse (Armstrong et al., 2023; Hamida et al., 2025; Lundgren et al., 2024). Reducing demand is also linked to sufficiency and sufficiency-based circular economy (Bocken et al. 2022). Businesses should offer socially relevant products and remain sufficiently profitable while limiting sales to what is necessary (Wells, 2016). However, current circular economy innovations often lack this sufficiency perspective, potentially hindering progress (Bocken et al., 2022). In SBM and CBM research, the focus is often on the outcome (Santa-Maria et al., 2021). However, aligning operations and BMs with sustainability requires innovation; indeed, sustainability is a key driver of BMI, including concepts like the sharing economy (Foss & Saebi, 2017).

BMI research takes a holistic view of innovation, encompassing theory, implementation, and experimentation (Bocken et al., 2019; Foss & Saebi, 2017). It involves innovation across multiple BM elements, often combined, and aligns it with overall principles (Bocken et al., 2019). Indeed, innovation is defined as the implementation of a new or significantly improved product or process aimed at reaching overall objectives, such as, creating value for organizations, communities, or society (OECD & Eurostat, 2018). OECD and Eurostat (2018) differentiate between product innovations for goods or services and business process innovations, the latter referring to the business functions supporting the former. A classification system for business processes, adapted from Brown (2008), is presented in the Oslo Manual (OECD & Eurostat, 2018) as follows: a) production of goods & services, b) distribution & logistics, c) marketing & sales, d) ICT, e) administration & management, and f) product & process development.

BMIs include all core business functions and products or services that firms utilise to achieve its strategic goals and objectives (OECD & Eurostat, 2018). Real estate and related activities as business processes are brought up by Brown (2008) as a topic of notable interest. BMI can have substantial effect on, e.g., value creation, supply chains, and the transformation of markets. Due to the complexity, instead of precise measuring of BMI, analytical estimations are recommended (OECD & Eurostat, 2018).

SBM/I and CBM/I share overlaps but differ in focus, making attention to both valuable (Pieroni et al., 2019). While SBMI often emphasises social aspects of sustainability, CBMI has been criticized for being driven by resource efficiency and economic growth. The social dimensions of the circular economy are increasingly gaining attention (Kirchherr et al., 2023), including e.g., human-centred circular economy (Schröder et al., 2020) and the notion of a circular society (Calisto Friant et al., 2024; Jaeger-Erben et al., 2021). Both sustainability- and circularity-oriented perspectives on BM/I rely on networks and multiple stakeholders, reflecting the boundary-spanning nature of business models (Antikainen et al., 2017; Brehmer et al., 2018; Tiemann et al., 2018; Zott & Amit, 2010). A broader understanding of value, including societal and environmental impacts beyond the firm, is essential (Bocken et al., 2019). Research highlights multiple levels of analysis: organizational (firm-level activities), inter-organizational (collaboration and co-creation), and societal or macro levels (Antikainen & Valkokari, 2016; Boons & Lüdeke-Freund, 2013). Increasingly, CBMI and SBMI research focuses on inter-organizational and societal levels, as this aligns better with the sustainable and circular aims, while general BM/I research remains largely on the organizational level (Pieroni et al., 2019).

2.2. Rural coworking as a circular business

Coworking spaces have gained increasing research attention in recent years (Kojo & Nenonen, 2017; Kyrö et al., 2025; Lundgren et al., 2022; Orel, 2019). Studies of CWS as CBMs have mainly focused on urban or unspecified contexts (Lundgren et al., 2022). In rural areas, hubs, i.e., agglomerations of activities and services,

both reflect local conditions and actively support regional development (Bosworth & Saleminck, 2021; Kojo & Nenonen, 2017; Lundgren et al., 2025). They can strengthen local economies, e.g., by enabling remote work, attracting skilled workers, and fostering economic growth (Rex & Westlund, 2024).

Rural hubs also provide accessible facilities and services (Kojo & Nenonen, 2017) and act as drivers of community interaction, collaboration, and innovation beyond their immediate business functions (Bosworth & Saleminck, 2021). When located in recreational areas, they further enable temporary work-leisure arrangements (Del Aguila Obra et al., 2002; Gann, 1991).

CWS may also activate underutilised buildings (Kojo & Nenonen, 2017; Montgomery, 2007), aligning with effective circular strategies that emphasise the use of existing resources (Thornton et al., 2023) and contributing to circular futures in rural hubs (Lundgren et al., 2025). The BM of CWS is closely linked to the sharing economy, offering shared facilities that reduce demand (Berbegal-Mirabent, 2021; Lundgren et al., 2022), a key aspect of the circular economy (Henry et al., 2021; Reike et al., 2018). As such, CWS increasingly systematise the sharing of infrastructure and human resources (Orel, 2019).

Thornton et al. (2023) provide a comprehensive analysis and taxonomy of BMs for rural CWSs, using the Triple layered business model canvas (Joyce & Paquin, 2016), an extension of the BMC by Osterwalder & Pigneur (2013), that incorporates environmental and social dimensions. Their findings highlight significant variation across BM elements, including value propositions, customer segments, resources such as site factors, and social stakeholder aspects, e.g., governance and community involvement (Thornton et al., 2023).

The motivation for implementing rural CWS is often situational and personal, reflecting diverse needs (Thornton et al., 2023). Unlike other sharing BMs, they are often driven by pro-social motivations (Lundgren et al., 2022). Rural CWS can support well-being by offering services and events scarce in rural areas, enabling flexible work arrangements, and reducing isolation (Merrell, Füzi, et al., 2021). They are most effective “*when they emerge in tandem with local needs and with respect for local preconditions*”, which broadens their user base and reduces dependence on external factors such as remote firms’ policies (Rex & Westlund, 2024).

Overlapping economic and social goals can foster entrepreneurship and more balanced rural communities (Bosworth & Saleminck, 2021). For users, local hubs offer access to networks, knowledge, and skills (Lundgren et al., 2022; Merrell et al., 2021). Rural contexts are more diverse than urban ones in terms of demographics and environmental circumstances, leading CWS business models to adopt hybrid forms shaped by local demographics, environments, and varied user groups (Thornton et al., 2023).

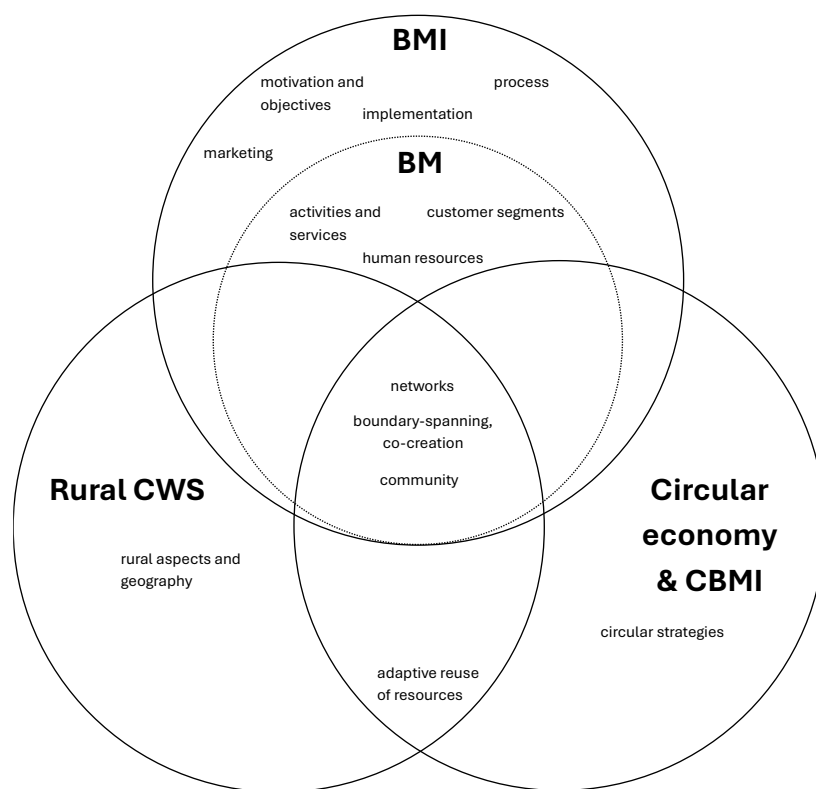


Figure 1. Relationships between concepts derived from streams of literature

Figure 1 illustrates how the presented streams of literature are related and the concepts derived from the review, while Table 1 presents the reviewed sources for those concepts.

Table 1. Streams of literature and key concepts derived from literature

Stream of literature (main)	Concepts	Found in
BM	<i>activities and services</i>	Osterwalder and Pigneur, 2013
	<i>customer segments and relationships</i>	Joyce and Paquin, 2016; Osterwalder and Pigneur, 2013; Thornton et al., 2023
	<i>human resources</i>	Zott and Amit, 2010; Osterwalder and Pigneur, 2013
	<i>boundary-spanning, co-creation</i>	Brehmer et al., 2018; Tiemann et al., 2018; Zott and Amit, 2010
	<i>networks</i>	Antikainen & Valkokari, 2016; Merrell, Rowe, et al., 2021; Thornton et al., 2023; Zott & Amit, 2010
BMI	<i>motivation, objectives</i>	Foss and Saebi, 2017; OECD and Eurostat, 2018; Thornton et al., 2023
	<i>process</i>	Bocken et al., 2019; OECD and Eurostat, 2018
	<i>implementation</i>	Bocken et al., 2019; Foss and Saebi, 2017; OECD and Eurostat, 2018; Thornton et al., 2023
	<i>marketing</i>	OECD and Eurostat, 2018; Osterwalder and Pigneur, 2013
Circular economy and CBMI	<i>circular strategies</i>	Bocken et al., 2022; Lundgren et al., 2024, 2025; Reike et al., 2018; Santa-Maria et al., 2021
Rural CWS	<i>rural aspects and geography</i>	Merrell, Füzi, et al., 2021; Rex and Westlund, 2024; Thornton et al., 2023
	<i>community</i>	Bosworth and Salemin, 2021; Rex and Westlund, 2024; Thornton et al., 2023
	<i>adaptive reuse of resources</i>	Kojo & Nenonen, 2017; Lundgren et al., 2025; Montgomery, 2007; Thornton et al., 2023

3. Research design

The paper employs a qualitative single case study strategy, to learn from a concrete, context-dependent case (e.g., Flyvbjerg, 2006). Given the exploratory nature of the emerging topic of study, a qualitative approach is appropriate, as it allows for flexible inquiry and the examination of complex and situational processes (Creswell, 2013). By relating the case study findings to the chosen conceptual framework, insights are gained that are relevant beyond the case itself (Saunders et al., 2019), which may allow for a transfer of this knowledge to related topics and other contexts.

3.1. Case selection

The selected case is an extreme case (Flyvbjerg, 2006), which, unlike random or typical cases, is particularly good or poor in some aspect, and is selected for its expected information content (Flyvbjerg, 2006). The case was selected using information-oriented, or purposive sampling. Purposive sampling is rooted in the foundations of qualitative research, where an emphasis is on depth and specificity rather than generalizability, making it suitable for exploratory research (Saunders et al., 2019). This method ensured an information-rich case relevant to the phenomenon (Campbell et al., 2020; Saunders et al., 2019), and was carried out based on certain criteria, namely, a) micro-location: rural area, b) circular resource use: adaptive reuse and c) circular-oriented BM: coworking.

The rural area was defined following the categorisation of Swedish municipalities by the Association of Local Authorities and Regions (Sveriges Kommuner och Regioner, 2023). The selected case is located in a *Rural municipality*, a category that comprise “municipalities with less than 15.000 inhabitants in the largest densely-populated area and a low commuting pattern” (Sveriges Kommuner och Regioner, 2023). The case

was identified through a research project on rural neighbourhood workplaces and services carried out by the Swedish Energy Agency in 2024 (D15).

The selected case is well suited to explore (Ragin, 2009) CBMI as it utilises the existing building stock and represents a renowned work-leisure complex with diverse services. The approach balances clear case boundaries with flexibility, allowing researchers to leverage the case's uniqueness without losing rigour (Eisenhardt, 1989; May & Perry, 2022). Moreover, the purpose of setting boundaries is not exhaustiveness, but rather “*meaningful analytic closure*” (Harvey, 2009; May & Perry, 2022).

3.2. Case description

The selected case, Climbers' Hub, is a hub located in a rural village of approximately 200 inhabitants in southwest Sweden. The Climbers' Hub functions as a collaborative ecosystem of separate SMEs (coworking, hotel, indoor-climbing, and retail). In cooperation they provide a wide service offering that may include services from several partners combined, e.g., co-living in the hotel including coworking desk space. The facilities of the CWS and the hotel, and the site on which all enterprises operate, is owned by one of the co-founders (hereinafter Owner). The legal form of the CWS is an economic association (*Swe. ekonomisk förening*) while the hotel is a limited company. The Climbers' Hub is anchored in a community of local and international climbing enthusiasts. The concept is place-based as the geographical area offers great opportunities for rock-climbing from spring to fall. The price range for the CWS, hotel and indoor-climbing is on the lower spectrum. Additionally, the CWS and the hotel host and provide space for free activities that are circularity-oriented, e.g., repair workshops, pop up-events for clothes' swapping, and small-scale farming. The main perspective of this study is on the CWS and the hotel as a joint small enterprise, while indoor-climbing and equipment store are viewed as part of the SME ecosystem.

3.3. Data collection

Primary data was collected through semi-structured interviews with the Owner and end-users on site. The interviews followed a guide including key questions based on the sustainable and circular BM framework, but with follow-up questions related to facilities and the development process. The 4 interviews lasted 15-60 min and were carried out in Swedish. The semi-structured interview as a method enables an exploratory approach to the dynamic nature of how these practices are described, as it allows interviewees to answer in their own words (May & Perry, 2022). Other sources of primary data comprise participant observation during a 24h-site visit, and photographs. Secondary data was gathered through websites, a radio show, newspaper and research. All data sources are listed in Table 3 in Appendix A, their strengths and limitations are discussed in the section Evaluation of study.

3.4. Data analysis

The analysis method chosen for this study is Thematic Analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2022; Saunders et al., 2019). This analytic process starts with coding (i.e., labelling) the data (Braun & Clarke, 2022; May & Perry, 2022). For this step, relevant concepts identified in the literature were used as the codes (Table 1). The software NVivo aided this task. Following coding, themes are developed through interpretative exploration of relationships between coded data chunks and organizing them into themes (Braun & Clarke, 2022). The procedure of coding and theme development enables a rich analysis in relation to the aim of the study.

4. Findings

The findings are organized in four themes (Table 2). The themes were developed from the empirical data using codes extracted from existing literature through the steps of thematic analysis. The findings are described and illustrated by data extracts in a narrative manner (Braun & Clarke, 2022).

Table 2. Theme summary

Theme	Characteristics
Motivation and objectives	Personal motivations and the overall objective for the Climbers' Hub
Community	Aspects related to the community and human resources supporting the Climbers' Hub
Circularity	Circularity-oriented activities and services, as well as circular material and spatial resources of the Climbers' Hub
Implementation	Implementation process of the Climbers' Hub, including factors driving decisions and critical events

4.1.1. Theme 1: Motivation and objectives The first theme captures the co-founders' personal motivations and their overall objectives for the place, its inhabitants, and broader societal goals related to health and sustainability. As the Owner stated, these objectives underpin all their actions:

“What is good for society? What is good for the locals? Then it is the [indoor-climbing] hall, it is health, good. A good everyday life, being able to live and work here...” (Owner)

On a personal level, the co-founders express a passion for outdoor activities and working with tourism. The income from their regular, mostly remote, work enable them to pursue this. On the business level, they are guided by the circular economy. This is manifested, e.g., through activities, such as pop-up events teaching circular practices, and services, such as a second-hand store on weekends, but also through practices included in the following themes.

Also, the climbing association had expressed a wish for all-year climbing opportunities in the area. This aligned well with the objectives of the Climbers' Hub, stressing the importance of keeping the place busy to create a sense of community and attract more activity, thus motivating the Owner to lease out land for constructing the indoor-climbing hall.

The climbing equipment store, which recently relocated to the village, has an approach that aligns well with that of the Climbers' Hub: *“A business should contribute to society, not just take.”* (D4)

They want the store to be a meeting point for the climbing community and be part of the enterprise ecosystem that grows on site. With the relocation, the aim is to down-scale the business to allow for a better, personal work-life balance and join the community rather than just facilitating it. The idea is to make it financially viable, not to upscale for the sake of upscaling. Such sufficiency ideals are manifested also in the BMs of the CWS and hotel, which follow a not-for-profit approach yet providing accessible pricing and free of charge activities for the customers.

4.1.2. Theme 2: Community The second theme encapsulates aspects related to the community, and how the BM elements, including activities, customer segments, and marketing are all anchored in the human resources.

The professional background of the Owner is as a researcher in marketing, including major experience in writing business plans, whereas the other two co-founders of the CWS are a software developer and an occupational therapist respectively. The latter two work remotely, are both passionate climbers and were first introduced to the Owner by a climber temporarily working at the hotel. The skills and competence of the co-founders were used, e.g., to develop online space booking systems, and attend to ergonomics for the CWS.

Resident and visiting climbers often work in the hotel during high season. For gardening of the large premises, a staffing company that facilitates temporary job placements for local retirees is used. The Owner works significant hours without salary, e.g., refurbishing furniture, hosting events, applying for permits and housekeeping. Apart from the official service offering, the Climbers' Hub engages in activities based on the skillset and assets of the people involved, e.g., sharing sewing machines, selling second-hand outdoor equipment, and hosting free-of-charge fitness events.

The CWS customer segment comprises local, national and international remote workers, often residential or nomad-working climbers. The hotel in turn hosts travelling climbers and other tourists. Another important segment is the artist community, due to a nearby Artist's Collective Workshop (Swedish KKV), where some coworkers work part time beside working remotely in the CWS. The customers of the indoor-climbing hall

include the above, but also local children. The restaurant is open to the public on weekends, also the free activities are publicly available. Marketing and promotion follow a community-based practice: *“It is much better that the consumers spread the word themselves.”* (Owner) This appears to be a successful approach within the community. One notable outcome was that it enabled the climbing equipment store to relocate its business from Sweden’s second largest city Gothenburg to this rural village.

4.1.3. Theme 3: Circularity This theme comprises activities based on circularity principles, such as, the utilisation of existing resources, multi-use of objects and spaces, and activities oriented towards sharing and sufficiency. The theme focuses on the material and spatial dimensions.

The CWS operates in a wooden building from 1906, that was originally used as a school and later in residential use for 50 years until sold by force due to neglect. When purchased by the Owner, the building needed renovation of the roof and electricity, and minor adaptations were required to meet the standards for fire safety and accessibility due to the public use of the CWS. Yet, the layout has been kept almost intact. *“Rather, we adapted the operations to the buildings.”* (Owner)

A coworker (I2) expressed the benefits of the various small rooms from the original layout, as people can go for phone and video calls, leaving the main workspace quiet. A separate and homely kitchen and a terrace serve as focal points for social interaction and break areas during the day. The climbing equipment store is located within this building in a former classroom. The hotel building, of similar construction type and age, did not require much adaptation due to a similar previous use. It has wide outdoor stairs that are used as seating for outdoor music events. Both hotel and CWS are used for extracurricular activities, such as, meetings and sewing workshops.

Most furniture is reused and only refurbished when necessary. Modern equipment, such as, ergonomic tables and computer screens were bought second hand, when possible.

4.1.4. Theme 4: Implementation The last theme describes the development and implementation process of the Climbers’ Hub, including factors directly driving decisions for the enterprises and events challenging or hindering the implementation, including slow permitting processes and financing, as well as personal and professional implications.

The first enterprise to initiate the hub was the hotel that opened in 2012 and was owned and operated by the Owner. Prior to this, the Owner had a second home in the village and was inspired to start their own enterprise when the sale of the hotel building was announced. Following a few years of co-ownership with a chef, the Owner assumed full ownership. At the same point in time a dialogue with the climbing association was initiated, and the newly constructed indoor-climbing hall opened in 2017. Throughout, the climbing community is a driving force that keeps the hub relevant and active. The development of the CWS was initiated when the three co-founders first met, but also when the sale of the CWS building was announced, as the Owner felt a necessity to buy it due to the risk of gaining a neighbour who would disagree with the other activities or the community. The CWS was renovated during Covid-19 and opened in 2021. The climbing equipment store, previously operated in a major town since 2001, opened as a tenant in the CWS building in 2025.

One challenge regards the permit process of Swedish authorities. When the CWS was initiated, a building permit was issued after all requirements were met. Despite this, the addition of the climbing equipment store within the CWS building required a new permit by the municipality. This was a long and costly process, even though no further adaptation was necessary. Overall, various permit and control processes are described as time and cost intensive, causing stress and uncertainty for the co-founders of the Climbers’ Hub and its tenants. Another challenge relates to financial aspects. The number of visitors can vary heavily and is often weather dependent. Budgeting is thus difficult. Moreover, seeking financial support from the state and the EU requires heavy administrative work. The long processes have required the participants to cover costs in advance risking that the funding would not be granted.

While the Climbers’ Hub relies heavily on the nature tourism enabled by the rural location, the rural context also suffers from a poor reputation, as described by the Owner:

“the [village] has always been viewed as ugly and smelly by the [coastal city] inhabitants where the king has been, and there is sailing ... Who could possibly be interested in visiting ... the [village]?” (Owner).

Further, practical issues challenging the circular objective arise due to the remote location. For example, waste management is not on the level of cities in terms of recycling, and limited access to public transport results in increased private car use.

The themes, initial codes from literature, as well as empirical evidence are presented in Figure 2.

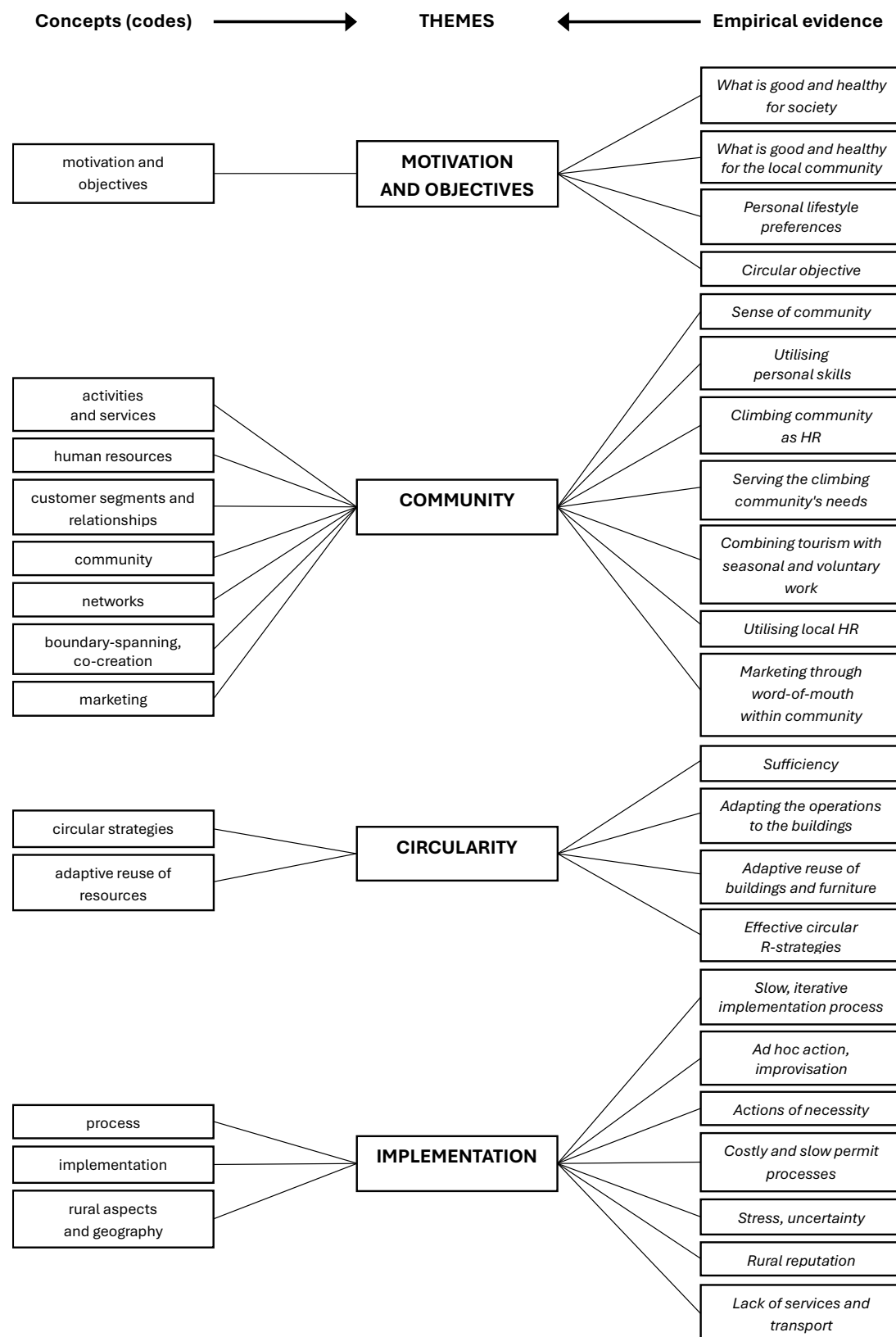


Figure 2. Themes developed from concepts based on empirical evidence

5. Discussion

This study set out to explore how CBMI unfolds within a small enterprise ecosystem operating in a rural context. More specifically, the aim was to investigate the role of motivation and objectives, community- and circularity-oriented aspects of CBMI and its implementation.

Foremost, the enterprise ecosystem works “in tandem” with the climbers’ community (Rex & Westlund, 2024), which has emerged due to the excellent rock-climbing opportunities in the area. In other words, the natural resources attract the community, as suggested by Orel (2019). The value proposition of the small enterprise ecosystem primarily serves this community. Secondly, the most effective circular strategies aim at reducing demand (Kirchherr et al., 2017; Reike et al., 2018). In the built environment these include sharing and multi-use of spaces (Lundgren et al., 2022, 2024), and BMs based on such strategies may be considered sufficiency-based BMs (Bocken et al., 2022). Our case suggests that sufficiency thinking and overlapping goals (Bosworth & Salemin, 2021) in small enterprises bring benefits in environmental, economic and social dimensions simultaneously. An illustrative example is that reduced demand results in lower costs which is translated, e.g., into an affordable price range for a diverse customer and user segment.

5.1. The role of motivation and objectives in rural CBMI

The aim of BMI is to realise strategic goals and objectives through innovation in multiple elements of a business model (OECD & Eurostat, 2018). CBMI is particularly complex and multifaceted (Bocken et al., 2019; Foss and Saebi, 2017; Santa-Maria et al., 2021). Our study suggests that a strong objective effectively guides both strategic and ad hoc decision-making, which is in line with previous research (Bocken et al., 2019). The alignment between personal motivation (Thirumalesh Madanaguli et al., 2021) and a circularity-oriented objective across the different enterprises of the Climbers’ Hub support long-term sustainability and value for the community, society and for the co-founders personally. This confirms the importance of the inter-organizational and societal levels, and networks in achieving circularity (Antikainen & Valkokari, 2016; Boons & Lüdeke-Freund, 2013; Labrousse et al., 2025; Pieroni et al., 2019), the importance of objectives in successful innovation (OECD & Eurostat, 2018; Zott & Amit, 2010), but also the importance of collaboration between small enterprises in rural areas (Kipinski et al., 2026). This study contributes to existing knowledge by confirming the role of strong, circularity-oriented objectives and personal motivation in CBMI in a rural context.

5.2. Community as a driving force for CBMI

Several BM elements, including the activities and services, of the Climbers’ Hub enterprises are anchored in the human resources. Most prominent is the incorporation of the leisure-oriented climbing community as a vital part, e.g., through temporary paid work, but also skills and engagement of customers and co-founders. The work-leisure combination thus contributes to the realisation of goals and objectives as defined by OECD and Eurostat (2018) and Zott & Amit (2010). Further, the community-based approach becomes evident in the marketing methods, as the pronounced policy is word-of-mouth among community members rather than traditional promotion channels. Pop-up events and free activities further act as channels to promote the Climbers’ Hub. Only rarely, social media are used to reach a wider audience. Through this, a diverse customer segment is reached for the various features of the Climbers’ Hub. This approach can be viewed through the lens of BMI and the business function categories (OECD & Eurostat, 2018), where it can be related to a) Marketing and sales, for analogue marketing methods and customer relationships, b) Administration and management, for the utilisation of skills and management of human resources, creating alliances, and strategic business management, and c) Distribution and logistics, for its wide service offering that supports a diverse customer segment of locals, tourists and nomad workers (Orel, 2019). An acknowledgement of the ecosocial benefits of community-based practices is thus most relevant. This study contributes to existing knowledge by illustrating how they amplify in combination (OECD & Eurostat, 2018).

Sometimes, such an approach may be seen as exclusive and too reliant on focal actors, as found by Lundgren et al. (2022) and Rashidfarokhi et al. (2026). However, inter-organizational SME collaboration is a vital enabler for circularity, as it reduces reliance on traditional promotion channels through community-based word-of-mouth practices, and allows for ad-hoc circular decision-making, granting the SMEs the flexibility to

identify and implement resource-saving adaptations that may be overlooked in more rigid, individual business structures. Overall, our study suggests that circularity in a rural setting emerges as the result of a robust SME ecosystem. Inter-organizational collaboration, where separate legal entities share an objective and physical assets, acts as a key enabler that compensates for limited external governmental support often prevalent in rural areas, while reducing the reliance on individual engagement. An illustrative example is the relocation of the climbing equipment store from an urban centre to the rural village, enabled by its integration into the growing local business ecosystem. This study contributes to existing knowledge by noting that rural CBMI benefits from a community approach and may even emerge as a result of a SME ecosystem.

5.3. Circular practices supporting CBMI

Regarding material resources, the Climbers' Hub utilises existing and available physical assets. The outspoken intent to "*adapt the operations to the buildings*", i.e., to keep the original layout, and adapt the use accordingly, was shown to be beneficial particularly for the CWS. Adaptive reuse as part of BMs and BMI is underexplored but substantially contributes to circularity (Lundgren et al. 2024). The circular spatial strategies may also be linked to several business function categories (OECD & Eurostat, 2018), namely, a) Production of services, due to the significant role of sharing and adaptive reuse in the production of the services, b) Distribution and logistics, because the adaptive reuse and place-based strategies lower the demand, e.g., for transportation, c) Marketing and sales, due to the pricing strategy anchored in the approach of adaptive reuse and flexibility, and d) Product and business process development, which includes systemic or ad hoc identification, development and adaptation of business products and processes, where the Climbers' Hub tends to prefer the *ad hoc* strategy to stay flexible. This study contributes to existing knowledge by identifying adaptive reuse, space sharing and other place-based practices as core resources in the innovation process.

5.4. CBMI implementation in a rural context

The studied case suggests that the implementation process of a CBMI is an iterative process, and in the rural context, shaped both by administrative and location-specific challenges. The rural context both limits options and offers unique opportunities, demanding thoughtful action, which makes the implementation a slow, learning-by-doing process. The prevailing BM research focus on results and outcomes underestimates the importance of this dimension (Santa-Maria et al., 2021). This study contributes to existing knowledge by confirming the need for a greater focus on the implementation process, including challenges, opportunities, and related stakeholders.

5.5. Evaluation of study

The particularly information-rich and unique case (Campbell et al., 2020; Flyvbjerg, 2006) allowed for an in-depth analysis of the complex phenomena that CBMI, particularly in a rural context, often entails. Yet, the single-case study design, limited number of interviews, as well as the short time span of data collection may be considered limitations. The primary data was, however, supplemented through further data collection techniques (May & Perry, 2022), including secondary data from interviews with other co-founders from a radio broadcast and tenants through newspaper articles. A 24h site visit including participant observation, the availability of rich online content from the individual businesses and from external sources constitute valuable data sources for the study. Data from online sources mainly includes practical information from websites, e.g., pricing and events, whereas data from social media was utilised to monitor use and frequency. Still, these limitations may influence, e.g., retrospective perspectives on the development process and events of the case. Applying this method longitudinally and extending the number of interviews to add more perspectives could bring further insights. However, the aim of qualitative, exploratory studies is not statistical generalization (Saunders et al., 2019) but rather analytical generalization, identifying patterns that may be transferable across cases. While the characteristics of the case may restrict transferability to other geographical contexts, transferability to similar contexts (i.e. circularity-oriented BM/I in rural areas with potential for tourism) is considered plausible. The repeatability of the study is enhanced by a detailed account of the research process (Saunders et al., 2019).

6. Conclusion

This study finds that CBMI benefits from holistic, community- and place-based strategies and reveals the gains to the rural community, society and the environment provided by this innovative, collaborative SME ecosystem. Particularly, the alignment between personal motivation and a circular objective across the different enterprises contributes to the success of this case of CBMI.

By framing the strategies of the Climbers' Hub within CBMI, this paper highlights the innovation that is being implemented in several BM elements. In particular, it demonstrates that inter-organizational collaboration within the rural SME ecosystem is a prerequisite for its successful circular implementation, as it allows for the cross-functional amplification of resource-saving strategies. Furthermore, it shows how adaptive reuse and place-based practices constitute a substantial part of the innovation process. An important finding of the study is how innovation is implemented across the BM elements, as the identified strategies are cross-functional. Thus, these strategies need to be considered jointly to fully catch the amplitude and effect that can contribute to the transition towards circularity.

Lastly, it may be concluded that implementation is not only a requirement for the definition of an innovation, but for the successful transformation towards environmental, economic and social sustainability. This study highlights the implementation process of CBMI as an iterative and explorative process of decision-making and action, shaped by challenges and unique opportunities. A greater focus on the dimension of the implementation process, including related stakeholders and actors, rather than only on the outcome, allows replicating the process to benefit society. Future research could focus even more on the implementation dimension to reach the overall objective of sustainability. Considering the many benefits that CBMI based on community- and place-based strategies brings to the rural context, the challenges to the implementation should be further explored and addressed both by researchers and practitioners.

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Author Contributions Author contributions as per the CRediT Taxonomy framework, as follows. Annika Falkstedt: conceptualization, data curation, formal analysis, investigation, methodology, validation, visualization, writing - original draft, writing - review & editing. Rebecka Lundgren: conceptualization, methodology, supervision, validation, writing - review & editing. Riikka Kyrö: conceptualization, funding acquisition, methodology, project administration, supervision, validation, writing - review & editing

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Data Availability Primary data include personal data and are thus not made publicly available. Data requests may be addressed to the corresponding author.

Declarations

Competing Interests The authors declare no competing interests.

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Appendix A

Table 3. Summary of data collection

ID	Data source	Date	Location	Participants / Topic	Duration / Pages
S1	Site visit	8-9 Oct 2025	Onsite	1 researcher Owner	24h
I1	Interview	8 Oct 2025	Onsite	1 researcher Owner	60 min
I2	Interview	8 Oct 2025	Onsite	1 researcher 1 Coworker	20 min
I3	Interview	8 Oct 2025	Onsite	1 researcher Owner 1 Coworker	15 min
I4	Interview	9 Oct 2025	Onsite	1 researcher 1 Employee hotel	30 min
O1	Participant observation	8 Oct 2025	CWS onsite	1 researcher	1h
O2	Participant observation	8-9 Oct 2025	Hotel onsite	1 researcher	12h
O3	Participant observation	9 Oct 2025	CWS onsite	1 researcher	3h
D1	Radio broadcast	7 Oct 2025	-	Live visit onsite and interviews with founders and users of CWS, indoor- climbing hall, shop	30 min
D2	Document	2025	-	Research article [source omitted for anonymity of case]	25 pages
D3	Photographs	8-9 Oct 2025			70 pictures
D4	Document	12 Feb 2026	-	Newspaper article climbing store	5 Pages
D5	Document	2025		Doctoral thesis	176 pages
D6	Website	Aug 2025 - Feb 2026	-	Website CWS	-
D7	Website	Sep 2025	-	Website hotel	-
D8	Website	10 Feb 2026		Website indoor-climbing hall	-
D9	Social media	Aug 2025 - Feb 2026		Facebook CWS	15 posts
D10	Social media	Aug 2025 - Feb 2026		Instagram CWS	10 posts
D11	Social media	Aug 2025 - Feb 2026		Facebook hotel	4 posts
D12	Social media	Aug 2025 - Feb 2026		Instagram hotel	0 posts
D13	Social media	Aug 2025 - Feb 2026		Facebook indoor-climbing	Active (closed group)
D14	Social media	Aug 2025 - Feb 2026		Facebook climbing store	1 post
D15	Document	2024		Report Swedish Energy Agency on Neighbourhood offices	